



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

A guard stands watch Jan. 26 in Baidi, Nigeria. Days before, militants believed to be linked to the Islamic State attacked.

In northwest Nigeria, the U.S. confronts a growing terrorist threat

Islamist fighters on the offensive despite December airstrikes ordered by Trump

BY RACHEL CHASON
IN BAIDI, NIGERIA

There are still bloodstains and bullet holes in the mud-brick alcove where villagers took shelter last month after militants overran their community, opening fire on residents who had gathered to drink tea in the town square. Six people, ages 18 to 60, were killed in Baidi that night, locals said, gunned down without warning by men whose faces were obscured by the darkness. The attack was the latest in Nigeria's northwestern Sokoto

state, carried out by what Nigerian and U.S. officials believe is the newest African affiliate of the Islamic State. On Christmas night, President Donald Trump announced that United States had launched airstrikes against the group, known here as Lakurawa, part of what the White House and its allies have described as a campaign to put a stop to the "slaughter of Christians" in Nigeria. But the U.S. strikes were largely ineffective, Nigerian officials, analysts and residents said, and there are very few Christians in Sokoto to protect. The state, once part of a 19th-century caliphate,

remains overwhelmingly Islamic, and it is Muslims in villages like this one who have borne most of the violence in Sokoto. Yet no one here denies there is a real and growing security crisis. Islamist militants from several different groups have wrought havoc in Mali, Burkina Faso and Niger in recent years while quietly extending their reach into northern Nigeria. Most researchers see Lakurawa as an extension of the Islamic State Sahel Province (ISSP), which is strongest along the borderlands between Mali and Niger but has shown the ability to

SEE NIGERIA ON A14

Slow gains in faculty diversity before ban

After modest progress, colleges roll back pledges amid Trump pressure

BY LAURA MECKLER,
LYDIA SIDHOM
AND ERIC LAU

When President Donald Trump took office last year, America's research universities were in the midst of an aggressive quest to hire more Black and Latino professors. All but three of the 187 most prominent schools had made public commitments to faculty diversity, pushed by years of student protests and demands, a Washington Post analysis found. Deploying a wide range of strategies, these schools made modest progress toward their racial diversity goals. The number of underrepresented faculty increased by a third, The Post found, from 9 percent in 2015 to 12 percent in 2024 among faculty whose race was known. That's higher than ever but, in virtually every case, lower than diversity among undergraduate students. Now most of these efforts are on ice or abandoned as the

SEE FACULTY ON A6



DYLAN MARTINEZ/REUTERS

Winter Games set to take flight

California-born Chinese Olympic freestyle skier Eileen Gu gets in some training at Livigno Snow Park, in Livigno, Italy, on Thursday, a day before the Milan Cortina Games commence. **Olympics coverage, B7**

The case of the severed pinkie and a judge's regretted mercy

BY DAN MORSE

The patient had just arrived at the hospital with nine fingers. The three cops standing in front of him were confident they had the other one. "I heard you're missing something," Officer Andrew Richardson said. "Pinkie," the man responded,

lying on his back and holding up his bandaged left hand. A half-hour earlier, and nine miles away, the officers had made a startling discovery: a little finger in the grass. They bagged it up — first in paper, then in plastic — as colleagues called local hospitals in search of a recent arrival who fit a specific description. And so here they were, speaking with

21-year-old Nasir Wilkinson in the middle of the night at Shady Grove Adventist Hospital in Rockville, Maryland. One of the officers held up the bag. "So, that is your finger?" another cop asked. Wilkinson's answer would come at the start of a case laced with horror and mercy, ven-

geance and justice. Before it was over, a stabbing victim near death would make a remarkable recovery. A judge would grant the attacker a lenient sentence. And the man's actions afterward would land him back to her courtroom. "It wasn't the hardest case I've investigated, but it was certainly the most unique," Sgt. John

Borowski said last week. **'Just don't stab him'** Before he picked up the knife, Wilkinson had been a star wrestler who won matches around the country. A diagnosis of Type 1 diabetes at age 14 hardly slowed him down as he attended two Maryland prep schools: St. Paul's **SEE PINKIE ON A11**

Minnesota courts crushed by weight of migrant cases

TEMPERS FLARE, AND JUDGES LOSE PATIENCE

Disputes over mandatory detention drive glut of work

BY MARK BERMAN
AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

The Trump administration says it has begun to scale back some of its immigration enforcement efforts in the Minneapolis region. But the massive strain the crackdown has placed on the area's courts and law enforcement is likely to linger for months to come. Government lawyers are buckling under a crush of hundreds of cases, including scores of challenges filed by migrants who say they are being illegally detained. Federal judges are running out of patience with what they describe as the Trump administration's repeated flouting of court orders. And immigration attorneys say they are drowning amid near constant pleas from noncitizens seeking help. A government lawyer's comment to a federal judge in Minnesota this week that she was so exhausted with her workload that being jailed might be preferable attracted nationwide attention as an unusually stark sign of those pressures. "Sometimes I wish you would just hold me in contempt, your honor, so that I could have a full

24 hours of sleep," said Julie T. Le, who had been temporarily assigned to the U.S. attorney's office in Minneapolis to help respond to the torrent of new filings. "The system sucks," Le said later in the hearing Tuesday. "This job sucks." Le was removed from her role after that outburst, administration officials said. But hers was hardly the only voice expressing deep frustration in recent days. Last week, Minnesota's chief federal judge, Patrick J. Schiltz, threatened to hold the head of U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement in contempt, accusing ICE of violating 96 court orders in January alone — more, the judge noted, "than some federal agencies have violated in their entire existence." He later backed off his contempt threat after the government released an Ecuadorian man whom the judge said had been illegally locked up for more than two weeks. But Schiltz noted that he and the district's other judges — all facing a glut of new cases — had already shown the

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Vanished: A fifth-grader thought missing is in Texas detention. **A4**

Russia fears for its war cash as West targets oil

Europe moves to crack down on Moscow's shadow tanker fleet

BY CATHERINE BELTON

Europe is tightening the net on Russian oil being shipped through its waters, squeezing Moscow's ability to fund its war even as officials and business executives in Russia fear the window is narrowing to reach a peace deal before the economy deteriorates. The European Union is considering imposing an outright maritime ban on services needed to ship Russian oil, such as insurance and transportation, as part of a new sanctions package marking four years of Russia's war. The ban would significantly ratchet up the sanctions imposed on Russian oil, replacing the current oil price cap system, and comes as 14 European nations including Britain, France and Germany warned last week they could intercept the shadowy fleet of tankers Russia created to help it evade sanctions, operating in breach of international maritime law.

Russian oil revenue plummeted by 50 percent in January compared with the same month the previous year after tough new sanctions imposed by the U.S. Treasury on Russian oil majors Rosneft and Lukoil in October. The penalties forced Moscow to accept ever-steeper discounts of more than \$20 per barrel for its oil. Combined with India's apparent agreement to halt Russian oil purchases in favor of increased imports from the United States and potentially Venezuela, the measures threaten to further strain the resources Moscow needs to fuel its war machine, risking crisis as nonpayments grow across the economy. Inspired by the seizure last month by U.S. forces of the Mari- nera tanker after a weeks-long pursuit despite a Russian submarine escort, the French navy briefly captured another suspected Russian shadow fleet tanker, the Grinch, which had been traveling from the Russian Arctic port of Murmansk across the Mediterranean carrying 730,000 barrels of oil under the flag of Comoros. French President Emmanuel Macron said the vessel was sub-

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Dialogue resumes: U.S., Russia renew talks halted by invasion. **A12**

IN THE NEWS

Democrats emboldened A Texas special-election victory has increased the party's confidence ahead of federal midterms. **A3**
'Very positive' Trump-Xi call The president was upbeat about his first contact with the Chinese leader after months of tension, while Beijing offered a more cautious take. **A16**

THE NATION **Record-low** temperatures have Floridians killing invasive iguanas stunned by the chill. **A2**
Sen. Elissa Slotkin rejected a DOJ interview request in the "illegal orders" video case. **A3**

THE WORLD **U.S. diplomats** foretold of an "apocalyptic wasteland" in Gaza in February 2024. **A16**
A former prince leaves a British royal residence amid scrutiny of the latest Epstein files. **A16**

THE ECONOMY **The president** is launching Trump-Rx.gov, a government website designed to help Americans buy prescription drugs at a discount. Experts say the initiative — one of Trump's top political priorities — could have a positive but limited impact. **A20**

STYLE **The breakup** of influencers Kristy Sarah Scott and Desmond Scott has both trying to rebuild their brands — separately. **B1**
SPORTS **American** figure-skating star Ilia Malinin is trying to reshape his sport's future. **B7**

THE REGION **The House** rejected D.C. tax changes, which may cost the city \$600 million in revenue. **B13**
THE WEEKEND **A western omelet?** A tall stack of pancakes? A booth where you can linger with a bottomless cup of joe? Local classic diners have you covered.

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